outside an alliance outweighed the risks. Advantages went beyond "enhanced" stature and a role in maintaining peace. Nehru stated that he did not want to "get into a position of bargaining for temporary benefits with one camp or the other."[37] What he left unsaid was that diversifying its partnerships put India in a position to gain benefits from both camps.

Nehru, on his part, showed more tolerance of other countries' freedom to choose a side. He acknowledged that, in some cases, it might be less risky to be in an alliance.[38] He even acknowledged that some countries that did not have the capacity to defend themselves might want foreign troops in their country.[39] And Nehru engaged with two Asian countries that had chosen to align closely with the US—Japan, whose prime minister he exchanged visits with, and South Vietnamese leader Ngo Dinh Diem, who visited India.

The Indian prime minister also showed less passion for the third way. He rejected calls for a commonwealth of Afro-Asian states, calling it impracticable. He did not think there were enough common interests or unity to make even another Bandung-style conference desirable or feasible.[40] As for a "third force," it had "no relation to reality."[41]

Furthermore, Nehru appreciated Eisenhower's attitude toward partners, including his statement during their conversation that "you cannot make friends by dominating them."[42] The prime minister disliked larger powers not treating smaller nations as equals or with respect—as he noted, "We are friends with every country but when somebody tells us, join up, line up, I am not a soldier to be recruited in a regiment."[43] For this reason Nehru believed that Soviet intervention in Hungary to crush a nationalist uprising had "undermined" both national and international communism. In contrast, when he returned from the US he especially remarked that the Eisenhower administration "went out of their way in showing me honour."[44]

Indian officials also realized that there was a growing awareness in Washington of the risks of alliances. After a visit from Dulles, Nehru noted that the US came across as "a weary titan trying to do good to the world but being let down by [its] allies and having to go to their rescue repeatedly."[45] The American refusal to support the Anglo-French-Israeli invasion of Egypt after the latter had nationalized the Suez Canal also made Indian policymakers aware that Washington could act on the merits of a case rather